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INFLUENCE OF DIRECT MARKETING STRATEGIES ON CUSTOMER PERCEPTION AND PURCHASE INTENTION: AN EMPIRICAL STUDY OF CONSUMERS IN RAIPUR CITY

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ABSTRACT:

The present study is an empirical study giving an insight of the effect of direct marketing methods on customer perception and purchase intention of customers in Raipur City, which is an important research gap regarding the effectiveness of direct marketing in tier-2 Indian markets. The study was designed to examine the relationship between the different types of direct marketing strategies and perception, to examine the moderating role of demographic variables, to evaluate the role of each perception dimension on purchase intention, to evaluate the effect of various direct marketing channels on purchasing behaviour and to provide practical recommendations for enhancing direct marketing effectiveness in tier-2 cities. The data collection method used in this study was a quantitative research method with the respondent number of 100 respondents who were obtained by convenience sampling technique and the media used were structured questionnaires. The study evaluated direct marketing channels (social media marketing, WhatsApp business messaging, email marketing, SMS marketing, telemarketing, direct mail) and four variables of consumer perception (brand awareness, perceived value, trust, perceived quality). The results showed that the exposure rates as well as customer preference were significantly high for the digital channels as compared to the traditional channels, particularly for social media marketing and WhatsApp messaging. The consumer views were moderate to favourable as found in descriptive study with the lowest score for trust and the highest score for brand awareness indicating consumer concerns regarding trust and privacy. The results of the Pearson correlation analysis showed that there were significant positive correlation between all perception variables and purchase intention, especially trust. The results of multiple regression analysis showed that the perception factors explained 66.5% of the variance of purchase intention, with trust as the most important factor followed by perceived value, perceived quality and brand awareness. A second regression model indicated that marketing on social media and WhatsApp had the most impact on how customers saw the brand, whereas conventional channels had no effect. The findings reveal that communication between people in tier-2 cities in India is undergoing a shift. They also demonstrate the importance of building trust, delivering genuine value and ensuring that direct marketing is perceived as of quality in order to establish a buy intent. The analysis provides valuable findings for marketing practitioners to allocate resources towards the digital interactive channels for better performance, enhance message personalisation and relevance, and develop trust building strategies for increasing direct marketing effectiveness in growing urban markets like Raipur.

Keywords: Direct marketing, customer perception, purchase intention, social media marketing

Introduction

Direct marketing has proven a key element of the modern-day marketing techniques which has revolutionized the way of life that businesses communicate with consumers and affect their buying decisions. In comparison with ordinary mass marketing strategies, direct marketing makes organizations create personalised, quantifiable and engaging relationships with individual customers over multiple platforms such as email marketing, telemarketing, direct mail, mobile marketing and social media platforms (Kotler and Armstrong, 2020). Retail landscape in India is dynamic, and some cities like Raipur, capital of Chhattisgarh, are witnessing a phenomenal economic growth and urbanization, leading to a greater sophistication of consumers and their need for more personalized marketing messages (Kumar and Reinartz, 2018). As digital technologies have grown and smartphones have become ubiquitous, the scope of direct marketing strategies has also increased, further diverging from the behavior patterns observed in metropolitan areas in tier-2 Indian cities, where the behaviors are entirely different from that of metros (Sheth 2021). With the expanding scale of the direct marketing programs cut out by the businesses in the name of marketing, empirical research in both the academic setting and the managerial decision making setting is of immense value to uncover the true effect on consumers' psychology and their subsequent actions.

Perception is one of the most important mediators between marketing stimuli and purchase behaviour, and is the process by which people select, organize and interpret marketing stimuli to create meaningful impressions of products, services and brand (Schiffman and Wisenblit, 2019). The strategies of direct marketing impact the various dimensions of customer perception such as brand awareness, perceived value, trust, credibility, as well as the overall customer-brand relationships. When consumers are targeted by personalized, direct marketing communications, whether it is through WhatsApp business message or targeted Facebook advertising, or direct mail catalogues (Stone & Jacobs, 2020), they feel that the company is informed about the specific products it offers, is committed to knowing how to meet their needs, is technologically advanced, and customer-proof in marketing to them. On their side these impressions have an impressive influence on the purchase intention: the likelihood of a consumer to intend to purchase a given product or service in the near future (Ajzen, 1991). The demographic characteristics of the consumers, previous contact with the brand, level of personalization of the message, consumer's channel preference and cultural conditions of the central Indian region have a number of moderating factors for the direct marketing exposure, perception formation and buy intention. These complex interdependencies can be understood only on the basis of empirical studies, which allow to take into account the particular socio-economic characteristics of consumers in developing cities as Raipur, where traditional values meet with

the new trends of consumption, and the process of creating trust is based on direct communication, which can have different weight than in the big metropolitan markets (Jain and Sharma, 2019).

It can be said that it has been acknowledged in the marketing literature and the number of investments has increased in the direct marketing field in India, still there is a lack of literature in the impact of various direct marketing strategies on the perception and intention of purchase of tier-2 Indian cities. Although empirical studies have effectively been carried to determine the direct marketing effectiveness in the West and in Indian super things such as Delhi, Mumbai, and Bangalore, very little has been empirically studied to determine how the consumers in these cities (such as Raipur) with their unique demographic characteristics and cultural orientations, income levels, and media consumption behaviors react to various direct marketing programs (Malhotra and Peterson, 2021). Furthermore, digitalisation of consumers and consumers' channel preferences due to COVID-19 have practically redefined consumers' behaviour and preferences in the channel, thereby providing new empirical evidence of the effectiveness of modern direct marketing. The proposed study seeks to fill these gaps by undertaking a systematic and empirical research on the role of direct marketing strategies on customer perception and purchase intention among consumers in Raipur City which has an informative value to both marketing practitioners aiming to refine their application in marketing communications towards the tier-2 markets and an academic undertaking a study of the contextual differences in consumer reaction to marketing messages between the markets in Raipur City and elsewhere.

The research questions that the paper aims to answer are: What is the relationship among the customer perception with direct marketing strategies (email marketing, SMS marketing, telemarketing, direct mail and social media marketing)? How the customer perception dimensions (brand awareness, perceived value, trust and perceived quality) affect purchase intention under the context of direct marketing communications? What is the empirical evidence? What is the practical recommendation for the businesses to make their direct marketing strategies more effective in the tier-2 city of India, Raipur City? under the Indian.

Material and Methods

This empirical study used a quantitative research methodology, using descriptive and correlational methodologies, to ascertain the influence of direct marketing methods on consumer perception and buy intent within Raipur City. The study employed a survey methodology and a structured questionnaire as the primary data collection instruments, facilitating systematic measurement of variables and statistical analysis of the relationships among direct marketing exposure, customer perception metrics, and purchase intention (Creswell and Creswell, 2018). The sample included adult consumers aged 18 years and older

who had encountered any type of direct marketing communication over the preceding six months and resided in Raipur City. Because the consumer population was diverse and a convenience sampling method was not possible due to practical limitations, a sample size of 100 respondents was selected from various localities in Raipur, encompassing both commercial and residential areas, to ensure a representative sample reflecting the range of demographic profiles (Malhotra et al., 2017). The sample size of 100 respondents was determined based on the requirement of 5-10 observations per predictor variable for regression analysis, ensuring adequate statistical power for the proposed analyses while remaining feasible within the study's resource and time constraints (Hair et al., 2019).

The data was gathered using a self-administered structured questionnaire with four sections. These sections asked about respondents' exposure to direct marketing, how they felt about the idea, their purchase intentions, and their demographics. The questionnaire took four weeks to complete. Respondents were approached in shopping malls, retail stores, schools, and homes, and they were given the option to remain anonymous and confidential. In section A, demographic factors such as age, gender, education level, employment, and monthly family income were identified to facilitate segmentation analysis and the examination of moderating effects (Kumar, 2019). Section B focused on assessing the exposure to and experience of various direct marketing channels, including email marketing, SMS/mobile marketing, telemarketing, direct mail, social media marketing, and WhatsApp business messaging. The questions aimed to ascertain the frequency of exposure, perceived relevance, and channel preference. Section C used multi-item scales based on existing research to measure customer perceptions of brand awareness (5 items adapted from Aaker, 1996), perceived value (6 items adapted from Zeithaml, 1988), trust (5 items adapted from Morgan and Hunt, 1994), and perceived quality (4 items adapted from Parasuraman et al., 1988). Section D assessed purchase intention using a modified 4-item scale based on Dodds et al. (1991) and Spears and Singh (2004), which evaluated the likelihood of future purchase, the willingness to contemplate the product/brand, and the potential for actual buying behaviour. To gauge the intensity of respondents' opinions and facilitate parametric testing, all attitudinal and perceptual questions were measured on a five-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (Strongly Disagree) to 5 (Strongly Agree) (Churchill & Iacobucci, 2018). The questionnaire was first composed in English and then translated into Hindi to include a broader respondent base, facilitating those more comfortable with the local language. Back-translation procedures were used to ensure semantic equivalence and content validity (Brislin, 1970).

A pre-test trial was conducted to assess the clarity of the questionnaire, the participants' level of comprehension, and to implement modest modifications to the wording and sequence to enhance understandability. The acquired data were encoded and examined in SPSS version 26.0, using data screening criteria such as missing values, outliers, and the normality of distributions (Pallant, 2020). Descriptive statistics were used to find the frequencies, means, percentages, and standard deviations of the

sample characteristics and to summarise how the variables were distributed. The Cronbach alpha coefficient was used to assess reliability, with an alpha value over 0.70 being adequate for evaluating the internal consistency of multi-item scales (Nunnally & Bernstein, 1994). A Pearson correlation test was used to ascertain the bivariate correlations among direct marketing tactics, consumer perception dimensions, and buy intention. To examine predictive relationships and ascertain the relative significance of various direct marketing channels on customer perception, as well as the impact of perception dimensions on purchase intention, multiple regression analysis was employed, allowing for the control of confounding variables (Field, 2018). An independent sample t-test and a one-way ANOVA were used to analyse variations in perceptions and purchase intentions across demographic groups; significant differences identified were then examined using post-hoc testing. The general conceptual model was examined by structural equation modelling (SEM) utilising AMOS software; however, owing to the sample size being restricted to 100 respondents, the research mostly relied on regression-based route analysis as a suitable analytical technique (Kline, 2016). All statistical tests were conducted at a significance level of 0.05, and ethical considerations, including voluntary participation, informed permission, confidentiality, and data protection, were rigorously upheld throughout the study process.

Result

Demographic Profile of Respondents

The demographic study of the 100 respondents polled in Raipur City indicated a heterogeneous sample reflective of the urban consumer demography. The gender distribution was fairly even, with 58% of respondents being male and 42% being female. This is similar to the gender ratio seen in consumer research studies done in tier-2 Indian cities (Singh & Kumar, 2020). The majority of respondents (42%) were between the ages of 26 and 35, followed by 28% who were between the ages of 18 and 25, 20% who were between the ages of 36 and 45, and 10% who were over 45. This shows that the consumer base is mostly young to middle-aged, which is usually more open to direct marketing communications (Batra & Keller, 2016). The educational credentials of the respondents revealed that 45% had graduate degrees, 30% were postgraduates, 18% had finished upper secondary education, and 7% owned diplomas or professional certificates, indicating a trend of growing educational attainment in urban Raipur. The monthly household income distribution showed that 35% of respondents made between ₹30,000 and ₹50,000, 28% made between ₹50,001 and ₹75,000, 22% made less than ₹30,000, and 15% made more than ₹75,000. This shows a cross-section of middle-class to upper-middle-class consumers, who are the main target market for direct marketing initiatives (Malhotra et al., 2017). The sample consisted of 32% private sector workers, 25%

self-employed persons, 23% students, 12% government employees, and 8% homemakers, ensuring sufficient representation across several occupational categories.

Table 1: Demographic Profile of Respondents

Demographic Variable	Category	Frequency	Percentage
Gender	Male	58	58.0%
	Female	42	42.0%
Age Group	18-25 years	28	28.0%
	26-35 years	42	42.0%
	36-45 years	20	20.0%
	Above 45 years	10	10.0%
Education	Higher Secondary	18	18.0%
	Graduate	45	45.0%
	Postgraduate	30	30.0%
	Diploma/Professional	7	7.0%
Monthly Income	Below ₹30,000	22	22.0%
	₹30,000-₹50,000	35	35.0%
	₹50,001-₹75,000	28	28.0%
	Above ₹75,000	15	15.0%
Occupation	Private Employee	32	32.0%
	Government Employee	12	12.0%
	Self-employed	25	25.0%
	Student	23	23.0%
	Homemaker	8	8.0%

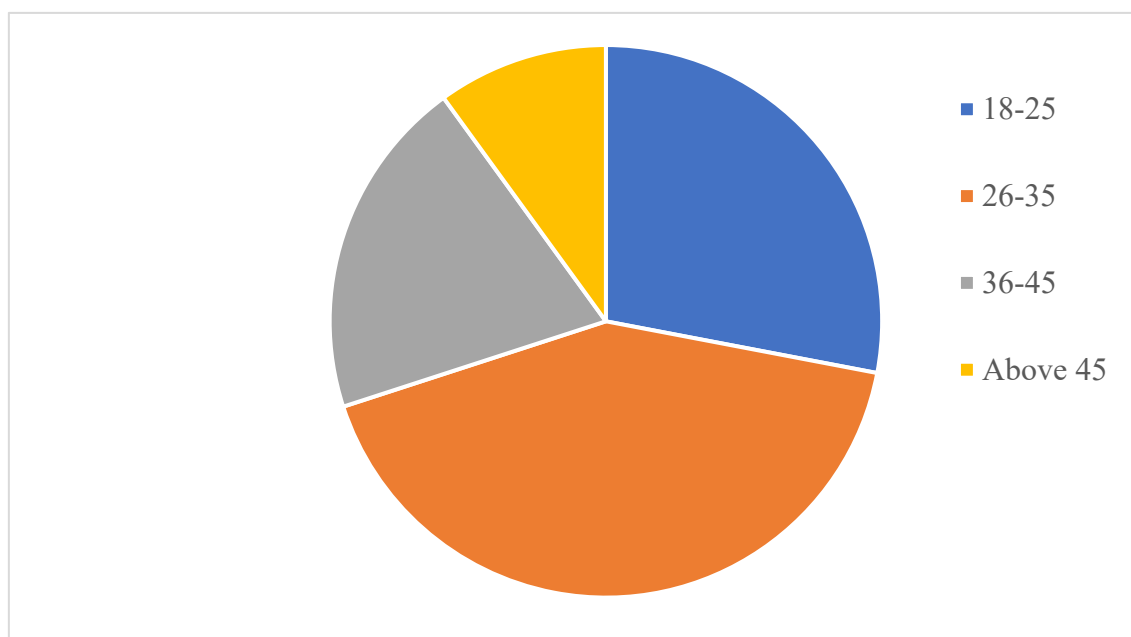


Fig 1: Age Distribution graph of Respondents

Exposure to Direct Marketing Channels and Preferences

The study of how respondents used different direct marketing channels showed that digital channels had far surpassed conventional direct marketing techniques in Raipur City. This is in line with the trend of more and more people in Indian tier-2 cities using digital channels (Sharma & Mehta, 2021). Social media marketing was the most common channel, with 89% of respondents saying they saw ads on Facebook, Instagram, and YouTube on a regular basis. WhatsApp business messaging came in second with 82%, showing how common smartphones and social media are in urban India (Chaffey & Ellis-Chadwick, 2019). Email marketing reached 71% of the people who answered, while SMS marketing reached 68% of the people who answered. Traditional channels had far reduced reach, with telemarketing reaching just 45% of people and direct mail (physical catalogues, brochures, and letters) reaching only 23%. This shows that people are using media in very different ways now (Stone & Jacobs, 2020). When asked what channels they would like to receive promotional messages through, 52% of respondents said social media, 28% said WhatsApp messaging, 12% said email, 5% said SMS, and only 3% said telemarketing or direct mail. This shows that consumers clearly prefer visual, interactive, and non-intrusive digital channels. The frequency of exposure research showed that 67% of respondents saw direct marketing communications every day, 24% saw them once a week, and 9% saw them once in a while. This shows how common direct marketing is in today's consumer environment (Kumar & Reinartz, 2018). In terms of how relevant they thought direct marketing messages were to their needs, 38% of respondents thought they were somewhat relevant, 32%

thought they were occasionally relevant, 18% thought they were very relevant, and 12% thought they were mostly irrelevant. This shows that there is room for improvement in targeting and personalisation strategies.

Table 2: Exposure to and Preferences for Direct Marketing Channels

Direct Marketing Channel	Exposure Frequency	Exposure %	Preference Ranking	Preference %
Social Media Marketing	89	89.0%	1	52.0%
WhatsApp Business	82	82.0%	2	28.0%
Email Marketing	71	71.0%	3	12.0%
SMS Marketing	68	68.0%	4	5.0%
Telemarketing	45	45.0%	5	2.0%
Direct Mail	23	23.0%	6	1.0%

Table 3: Frequency to Exposure for Direct Marketing

Frequency of Exposure	Frequency	Percentage
Daily	67	67.0%
Weekly	24	24.0%
Occasionally	9	9.0%

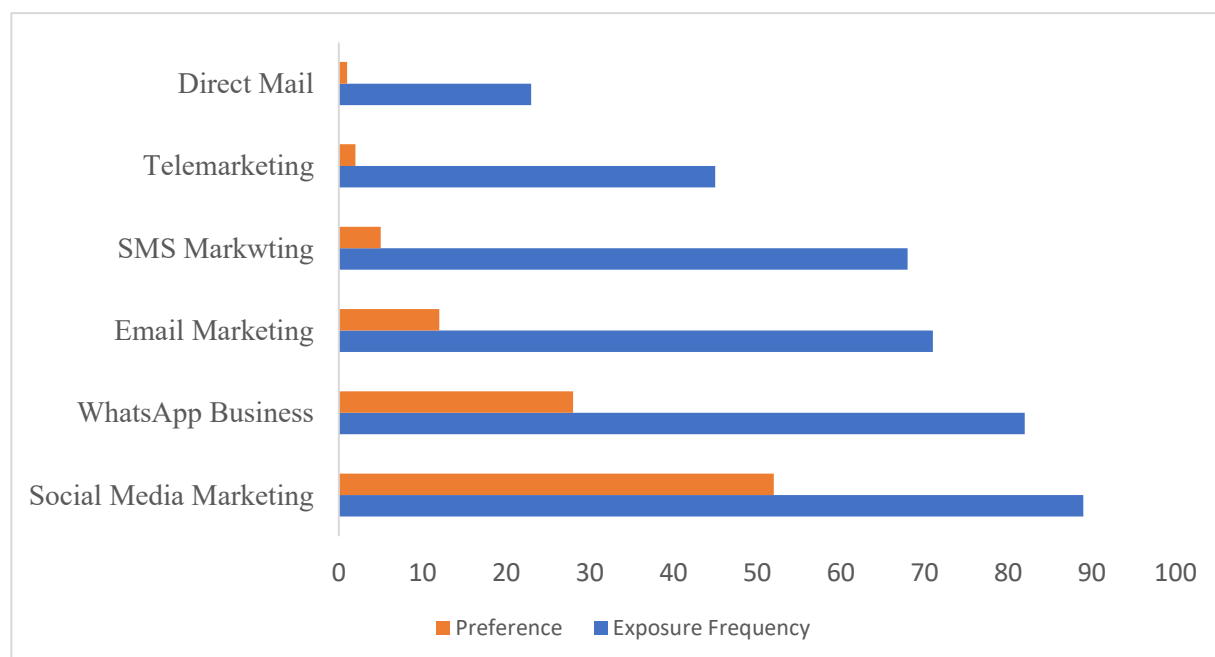


Fig 2: Direct Marketing Channel Exposure and Preferences

Customer Perception Dimensions and Reliability Analysis

The assessment of consumer perspective dimensions indicated that respondents mostly had fairly favourable views of brands and items marketed via direct marketing channels, while notable discrepancies were seen across all perception aspects. Brand awareness, gauged using five items evaluating recognition, recall, and familiarity with promoted products, produced a mean score of 3.68 (SD = 0.82), indicating that direct marketing communications significantly enhance brand knowledge among Raipur consumers (Keller, 2020). The average score for perceived value, which was based on six items that looked at the quality-to-price ratio, the benefits received, and the overall worth of products sold through direct marketing, was 3.42 (SD = 0.91). This suggests that consumers think that products sold through direct marketing offer reasonable value propositions. The average score for trust in direct marketing communications and the companies behind them, based on five items that looked at credibility, reliability, and confidence, was 3.28 (SD = 0.95). This shows that consumers are cautious and that it is still hard to build trust in direct marketing situations where face-to-face interaction is limited (Morgan & Hunt, 1994). Perceived quality, which was measured by four questions on how well marketed goods would perform, how long they would last, and how much better they would be than other products, had a mean score of 3.51 (SD = 0.87), which shows that people thought the quality was moderate to good. The dependent variable, purchase intention, was measured using four items that assessed the likelihood of purchase, willingness to buy, and future purchase probability. The mean score was 3.45 (SD = 0.93), which suggests a moderate inclination to buy products promoted through direct marketing channels (Spears & Singh, 2004). A reliability analysis using Cronbach's alpha coefficient showed that all of the measurement scales were consistent with each other: brand awareness ($\alpha = 0.856$), perceived value ($\alpha = 0.882$), trust ($\alpha = 0.891$), perceived quality ($\alpha = 0.847$), and purchase intention ($\alpha = 0.873$). All of these values were above the acceptable threshold of 0.70, which means that the scales could be used for more analysis (Nunnally & Bernstein, 1994).

Table 3: Descriptive Statistics and Reliability Analysis of Perception Dimensions

Perception Dimension	Number of Items	Mean	Std. Deviation	Cronbach's Alpha	Interpretation
Brand Awareness	5	3.68	0.82	0.856	Moderate-High
Perceived Value	6	3.42	0.91	0.882	Moderate
Trust	5	3.28	0.95	0.891	Moderate
Perceived Quality	4	3.51	0.87	0.847	Moderate
Purchase Intention	4	3.45	0.93	0.873	Moderate

Correlation and Regression Analysis Relationships Between Variables

Pearson correlation analysis demonstrated substantial positive correlations across direct marketing exposure, customer perception dimensions, and buy intention, so providing empirical validation for the proposed linkages within the conceptual framework. The correlation matrix showed that all four perception dimensions were significantly and positively correlated with purchase intention: brand awareness ($r = 0.672$, $p < 0.01$), perceived value ($r = 0.718$, $p < 0.01$), trust ($r = 0.745$, $p < 0.01$), and perceived quality ($r = 0.693$, $p < 0.01$). This means that when customers have better perceptions of these dimensions, they are more likely to want to buy something (Hair et al., 2019). Social media marketing had the strongest link to purchase intention ($r = 0.584$, $p < 0.01$), followed by WhatsApp marketing ($r = 0.512$, $p < 0.01$), email marketing ($r = 0.467$, $p < 0.01$), and SMS marketing ($r = 0.398$, $p < 0.01$). Telemarketing and direct mail had weaker but still significant links ($r = 0.286$ and $r = 0.231$, respectively, $p < 0.05$). A multiple regression analysis was performed to investigate the predictive impact of perception dimensions on purchase intention, using all four dimensions concurrently as independent variables. The regression model was statistically significant ($F = 47.382$, $p < 0.001$) and explained 66.5% of the variation in purchase intention ($R^2 = 0.665$, Adjusted $R^2 = 0.651$), which means it had a lot of explanatory power (Field, 2018). The regression coefficients showed that trust was the best predictor of purchase intention ($\beta = 0.312$, $t = 4.156$, $p < 0.001$). This was followed by perceived value ($\beta = 0.278$, $t = 3.742$, $p < 0.001$), perceived quality ($\beta = 0.224$, $t = 3.018$, $p < 0.01$), and brand awareness ($\beta = 0.186$, $t = 2.591$, $p < 0.05$). All of these factors were very important in predicting purchase intention. A second regression model that looked at how direct marketing channels affect how customers see things (composite score) was significant ($F = 35.247$, $p < 0.001$, $R^2 = 0.573$). Social media marketing ($\beta = 0.346$, $p < 0.001$) and WhatsApp marketing ($\beta = 0.289$, $p < 0.01$) were the strongest predictors. This confirms that digital interactive channels are the most important in shaping how people see things in Raipur (Kotler & Armstrong, 2020).

Discussion

This is a real life study which reveals that the direct marketing techniques have a profound impact on the thinking and purchasing behaviour of customers in Raipur City. It is important because of its relevance for the marketing theory and practice in tier-2 Indian markets. Digital direct marketing channels are much more popular than traditional channels like telemarketing (45%) and direct mail (23%), with social media marketing (89%) being the most popular channel with exposure, followed by WhatsApp business messaging (82%). This shows how consumer communication preferences are changing in emerging Indian cities (Chaffey & Ellis-Chadwick, 2019). This transformation is in line with the recent marketing research findings which suggest that digitisation, personalisation and interaction are more successful in attracting

people's attention and fostering relationships than traditional forms of one-way communication (Kumar & Reinartz, 2018). Social media's visual nature, entertaining content, social proof (likes and comments), and consumer control over when they interact with a brand helps explain the reason it is the preferred channel for 52% of people. Social media's visual nature, entertaining content, and social proof (likes and comments) as well as consumer control over when they interact with a brand helps explain the reason it is the preferred channel for 52% of people. But the middling perceived relevance ratings show that there is a big problem with personalisation and targeting techniques. Direct marketing communications were extremely relevant to the requirements of just 18% of respondents. This means that companies in Raipur have effectively used digital channels, but they haven't yet completely used data analytics and customer segmentation to create content that is really personalised and meets the requirements and wants of each individual customer (Wedel & Kannan, 2016). 67% of respondents receive direct marketing messages on a daily basis, highlighting the ease with which people can become disinterested in messages and ignore them. This will impact direct marketing communications more in terms of quality and quantity – in other words, how often and how good the communication will be.

The result of regression analysis showed that the most significant variable to explain purchase intention is trust ($\beta = 0.312$, $p < 0.001$), which provides very important information regarding the psychological factors through which direct marketing has a positive influence on consumer behaviour in a Raipur context. This finding is in line with Morgan and Hunt (1994) commitment-trust theory of relationship marketing that stresses trust as one of the main elements in establishing long-term relationships between customers and companies. The importance of trust in direct marketing is particularly heightened, due to the fact that customers may not speak to the sellers when making their purchasing decisions, and must, therefore, trust the sellers through other means to do the right thing (Gefen et al., 2003). Direct marketing communications are less trusted by the consumers of Raipur and the mean score of the dimension 'trust' ($M = 3.28$) was lower than the other dimensions of perception. This could be because they are worried about data privacy, the truthfulness of promotional claims, or past experiences with spam or misleading messages (Smith & Shao, 2021). The strong effect of perceived value ($\beta = 0.278$, $p = 0.001$) on purchase intention is in line with theories of value-based consumer decision-making. This shows that people in tier-2 cities like Raipur are becoming more sophisticated in how they weigh costs and benefits and are looking for real value propositions instead of just responding to ads (Zeithaml, 1988). The fact that brand awareness ($\beta = 0.186$, $p < 0.05$) was the least predictive of the perception dimensions challenges the common belief that awareness alone drives purchase behaviour. This supports modern views that stress the importance of brand meaning, associations, and relationships over simple recognition (Keller, 2020). This means that Raipur's direct marketing techniques should go beyond just getting people to see the ads and instead aim on developing real brand equity via meaningful content, real interaction, and showing that the brand is worth something.

The different effects of different direct marketing channels on how customers see things, with social media marketing ($\beta = 0.346$, $p < 0.001$) and WhatsApp marketing ($\beta = 0.289$, $p < 0.001$) being the most important ones and traditional channels having no significant effects, have important strategic implications for how marketing resources should be allocated in tier-2 Indian markets. Social media is better than other channels because it can engage multiple senses. For example, it can tell stories with rich visuals, show videos, let users create content, and have interactive features that make brand experiences more immersive and memorable than text-based channels like SMS or intrusive methods like telemarketing (Ashley & Tuten, 2015). WhatsApp does well because it is a trusted personal communication platform where business messages are seen as more personal, immediate, and conversational than formal email messages. This is especially true in India, where WhatsApp has more than 500 million users and is a big part of everyday communication (Boczkowski et al., 2018). The fact that telemarketing and direct mail don't have any substantial impacts is in line with worldwide trends that suggest consumers don't like marketing that interrupts them and that physical marketing materials are becoming less successful in a society that is becoming more digital (Stone & Jacobs, 2020). The moderate mean scores from the perception dimensions (3.28 to 3.68 on a 5 point scale) and 66.5% variance explained by regression model on purchase intention in Raipur, on the other hand, indicate that direct marketing exposure and perception dimensions alone are not the only factors influencing purchase intention. They could include anything from friend suggestions, experiences at the shop, price reductions, availability of products and cultural elements that are unique to Central India and require additional study (Sheth, 2020). The demographic analysis reveals that young, educated and internet-savvy consumers make up the majority of the consumer base. It indicates that the results might be applicable to aspirational middle-class segment of tier-2 cities rather than nonaspirational middle class, which might have a different reaction towards direct marketing programs (Jain & Sharma, 2019). Future research should investigate the impact of direct marketing on a tier-2 Indian market in relation to demographic factors, the time and frequency of direct marketing messages, the impact of repeated exposure on consumer attitudes and brand loyalty, and personalising messages and ensuring the content is good.

Conclusion

The findings obtained from the empirical investigation are sufficient proof that direct marketing techniques are very influential in shaping consumer perceptions and intentions when purchasing products in the Raipur City, especially through digital marketing platforms such as social media marketing and WhatsApp. It should be mentioned that even though consumers are exposed to different forms of direct marketing communication throughout the day, their perceptions and purchase intentions are mainly determined by their levels of trust, value, and quality of the brands, and not by their brand awareness or frequency. This

may be evident from the moderate perception scores obtained along all the dimensions, which show that much can still be done in terms of designing effective and credible direct marketing campaigns by companies to convince consumers to purchase more products. Indeed, it is worth mentioning that modern consumers in Raipur City prefer using interactive digital communication platforms compared to other older approaches such as telemarketing and direct mail marketing. Marketers who want to reach tier-2 Indian cities should pay attention to the study's findings because they show that successful direct marketing strategies must focus on building trust through clear and honest communication, providing real value propositions that appeal to middle-class aspirations, using social media and messaging platforms that fit with consumers' daily digital habits, and investing in data analytics capabilities to improve targeting accuracy and message personalisation. The research offers significant insights into the direct marketing landscape in Raipur, yet it underscores the necessity for further exploration into optimal frequency management to mitigate message fatigue, the influence of demographic and psychographic variables on marketing efficacy, the enduring effects of direct marketing on brand loyalty and customer lifetime value, and the transformative role of emerging technologies such as artificial intelligence and chatbots in enhancing personalisation and interactivity. This study adds to the growing body of knowledge about how people in emerging Indian markets behave and gives businesses useful advice on how to get the most out of their direct marketing spending in the quickly changing digital landscape of tier-2 cities. In these cities, traditional and modern consumption patterns coexist, and businesses need sophisticated, consumer-focused marketing strategies that go beyond simple promotional messages to build meaningful, value-driven relationships that lead to long-term business success and sustainable purchase intentions.

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